

# Saudi Football Study

Mapping supply against demand to grow  
Saudi football, prepared for **SAFF**  
**management**

*Prepared by Abdulrahman Bajunaid*

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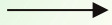
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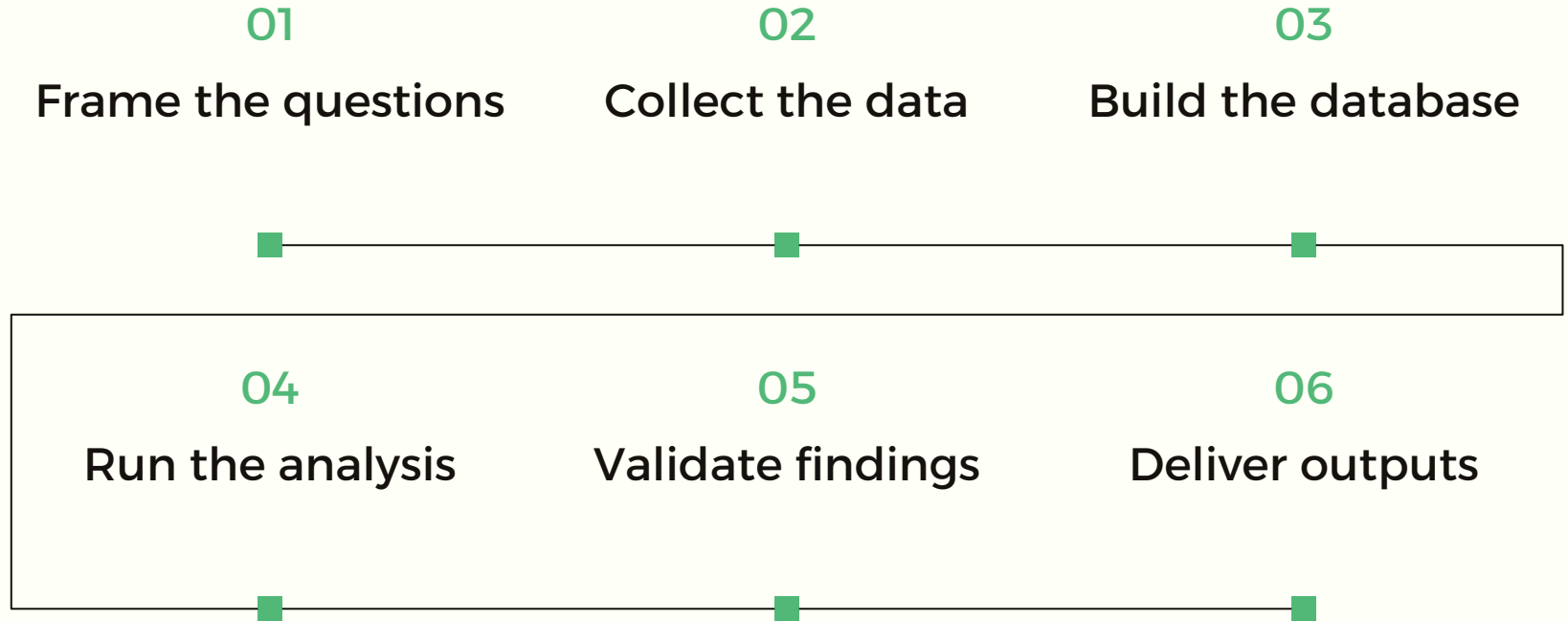


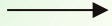
How we approached the study, week by week

01

# Project journey

# Project journey: 6 phases





Data sources, denominators, decisions

02

# Methodology

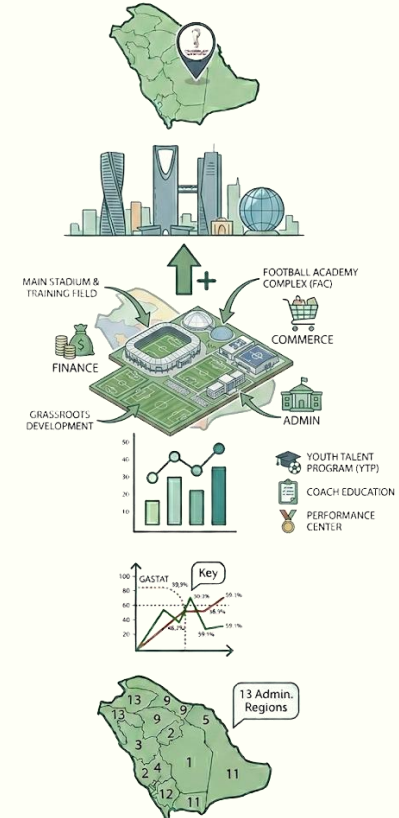
# How we approached it

## Data & Methodology

- **Supply vs. Demand:** Maps nearly 2,000 football facilities and SAFF accreditations against GASTAT 2024-2025 population and activity data.
- **Benchmarking:** Uses per-10k denominators to align with international standards (Sport England/UK ONS).

## Scope & Findings

- **Granularity:** Analyzed 13 administrative regions and five major cities (Riyadh, Jeddah, Makkah, Madinah, and Dammam).
- **Correlation:** Tested both unweighted and population-weighted correlations.



# Three data pillars

## Facilities database

1,997 facilities collected via Google Places API, mapped to region, city, lat/long. Each row has type, rating, review count.



## Demographics & Physical Activity

GASTAT 2024 population estimates, GASTAT 2025 physical activity stats, GASTAT 2021 sports practice survey for the gender breakdown.



## SAFF + MOS

SAFF October 2023 PDF (69 entries), MOS commercial halls open data (3,116 rows including 1,175 women halls).





Confidence per source, gaps, caveats

03

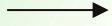
# Data quality score



# Data quality score per source

| Source                     | Records | Recency  | Coverage | Match | Confidence |
|----------------------------|---------|----------|----------|-------|------------|
| Facilities (Google Places) | 1,997   | Apr 2026 | 96.3%    | —     | High       |
| Demographics (GASTAT)      | 13      | 2024     | 100%     | —     | High       |
| PA stats (GASTAT)          | 13      | 2025     | 100%     | —     | High       |
| SAFF accreditation         | 69      | Oct 2023 | 100%     | 32%   | Medium     |
| MOS commercial halls       | 3,116   | 2024     | 100%     | —     | High       |

Match means that 32% of the SAFF (Oct 2023) data matches the new facilities database.



Diagrams and insights for Q1 to Q10

04

# Key results

# Where the supply sits

# 1,997

Facilities mapped across 13 regions

# 4.6%

SAFF accredited (22 of 473 clubs & academies)

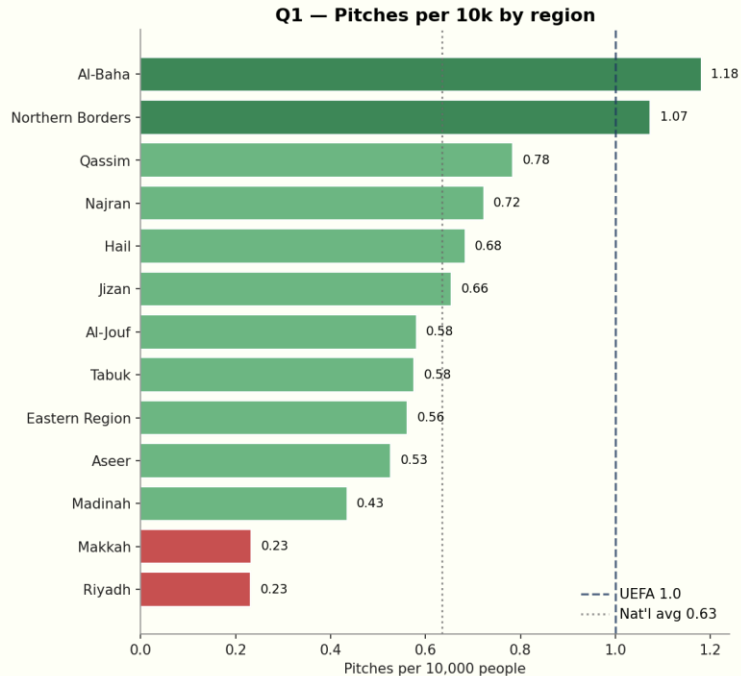
## 1,000 football facilities

Mapped April 2026 · Google Places API



Static snapshot. Live, filterable view available in the Power BI dashboard.

# Q1 — How many pitches per 10,000 people in each region?



## Answer

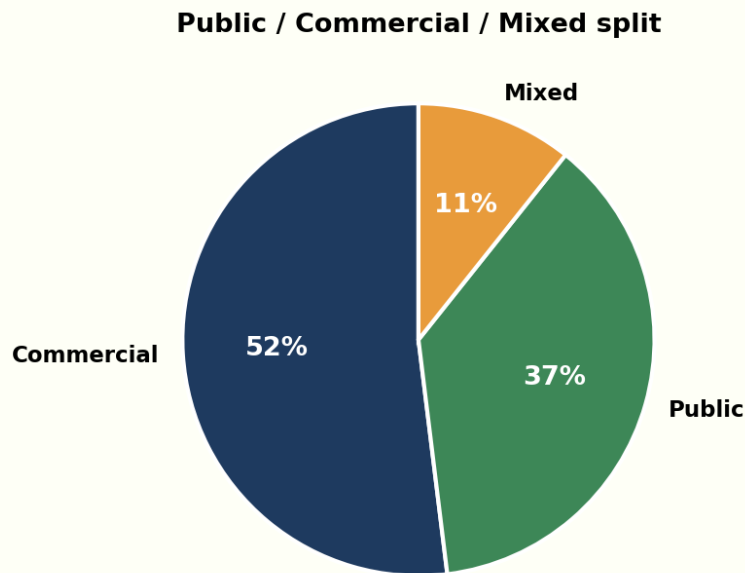
National average **0.43**. Range **1.18** (Al-Baha) to **0.23** (Riyadh, Makkah). Megaregions sit at one quarter of the UEFA 1.0 benchmark. 5x spread.

## Recommendation

Prioritize new pitch construction in Riyadh and Makkah 0.23 to address the severe supply gap. Avoid further expansion in Al-Baha 1.18 and the Northern Borders 1.07, as these regions already exceed the UEFA benchmark.

Source: Google Places API (1,997 facilities, Apr 2026) ÷ GASTAT 2024 population estimates. UEFA benchmark from Sport England.

## Q2 — What is the public, commercial, and mixed split?



### Answer

Commercial **52%** · Public **37%** · Mixed **11%**  
Sector is commercial-led: padel and branded academies dominate; public stock is mostly schools and municipal courts.

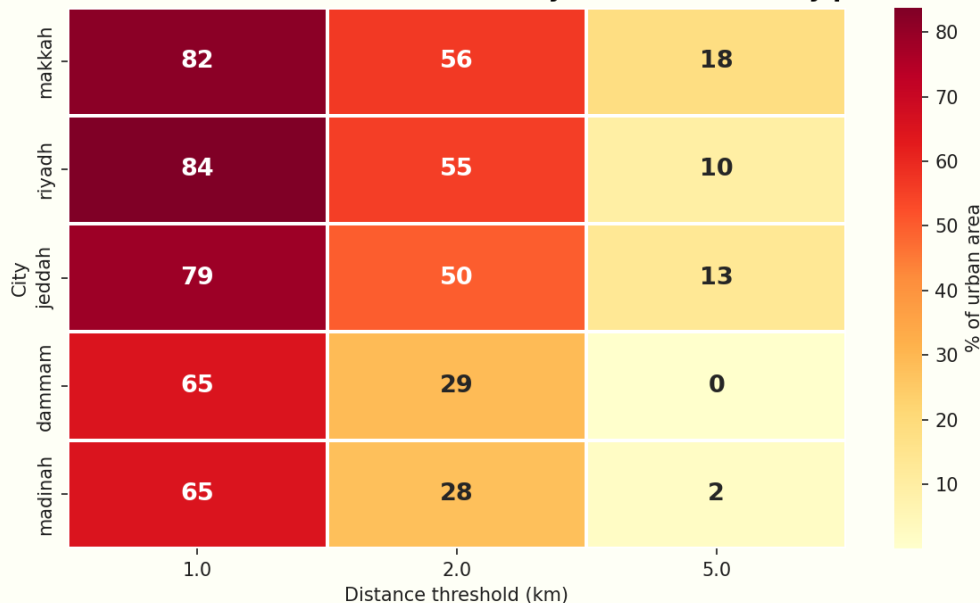
### Recommendation

Leverage the dominant Commercial sector (52%)—specifically padel chains and branded academies—through re-tagging schemes to quickly scale access.

**Source:** School/municipal/government → public; padel, branded English-named businesses, named-academy chains → commercial; SAFF-affiliated clubs → mixed.

# Q3 — Where are the pitch deserts in the 5 major cities?

Q3 — Pitch deserts: % of urban area beyond N km from any pitch



## Answer

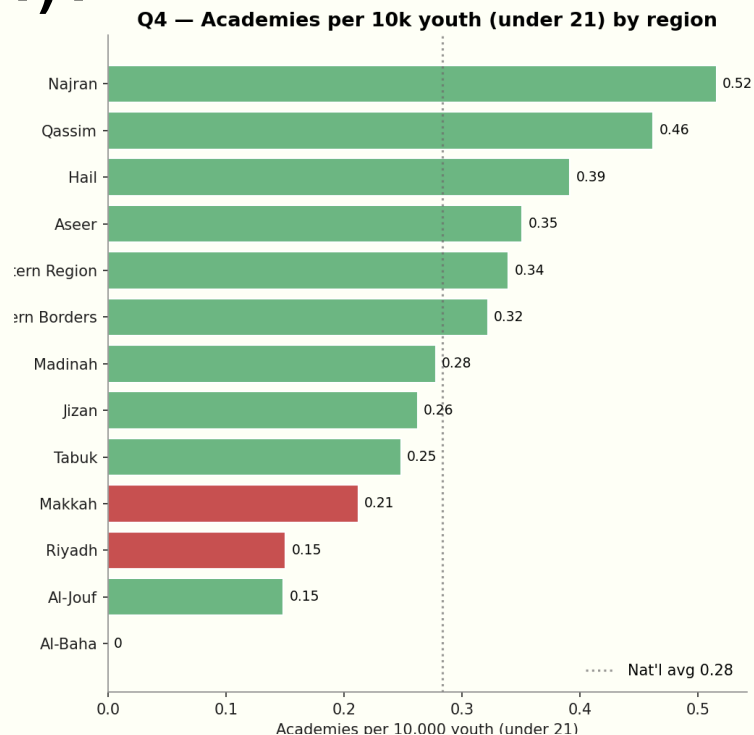
At the 2 km threshold: Riyadh **55%**, Makkah **56%**, Jeddah **50%** of urban area is desert. Dammam and Madinah are well-served (**29%** / **28%**). Megacities with most absolute pitches still have intra-city access gaps.

## Recommendation

Prioritize Riyadh and Makkah for desert-filling — re-tag existing pitches and add school partnerships before greenfield construction.

Source: Geospatial computation: convex hull + 1km buffer, 500m grid, Haversine distance to nearest pitch. Euclidean (real walking is 1.2-1.4× longer).

## Q4 — How many academies per 10,000 youth (under 21)?



### Answer

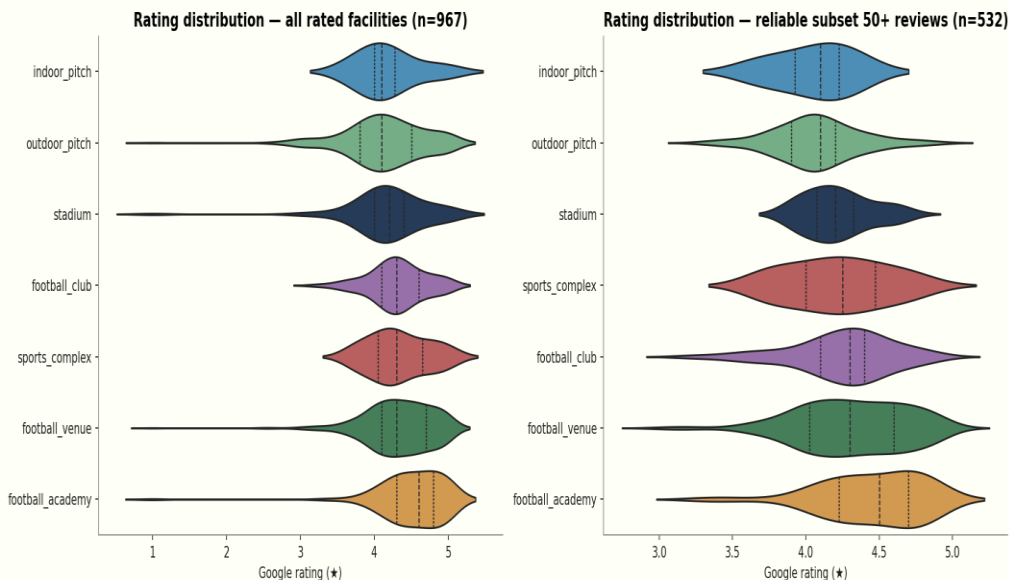
National average **0.28**. Najran **0.52** and Qassim **0.46** lead the regions, while Riyadh **0.15**, Al-Jouf **0.15**, and Al-Baha **0** trail significantly. Megaregions remain under-supplied—following the same pattern as Q1.

### Recommendation

Seed academies in Al-Baha 0 and Riyadh/Al-Jouf 0.15 before expanding in already well-supplied regions like Najran 0.52 and Qassim 0.46.

Source: Google Places API academies ÷ GASTAT youth under 21 (calibrated to national 10.8M).

# Q5 — How reliable are Google ratings as a quality signal?



## Answer

**96%** of facilities are rated. Reliable subset (50+ reviews) covers **47%** — these average **4.2★**. Below 50 reviews ratings are statistically noisy and should be ignored as quality signal.

## Recommendation

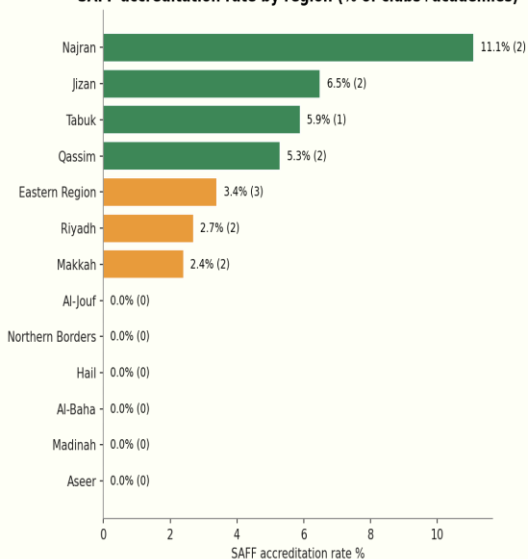
Use 50+ review threshold as the operational quality signal. Below 10 reviews, ignore ratings entirely. Build a SAFF-verified badge to displace noisy ratings.

Source: Google Places API rating + reviews\_count fields. Reliability threshold based on standard error analysis.

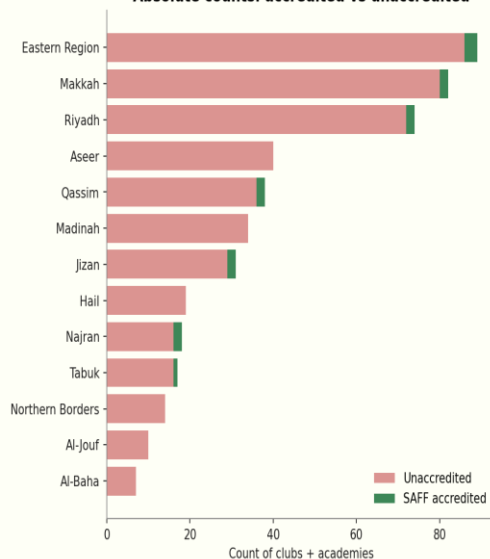


# Q6 — What is the SAFF accreditation rate, and where?

SAFF accreditation rate by region (% of clubs+academies)



Absolute counts: accredited vs unaccredited



## Answer

**4.6%** national rate — only **22 of 473** clubs and academies. **6 of 13** regions at zero. Najran leads at **11%**. Accreditation is not yet a market signal at scale.

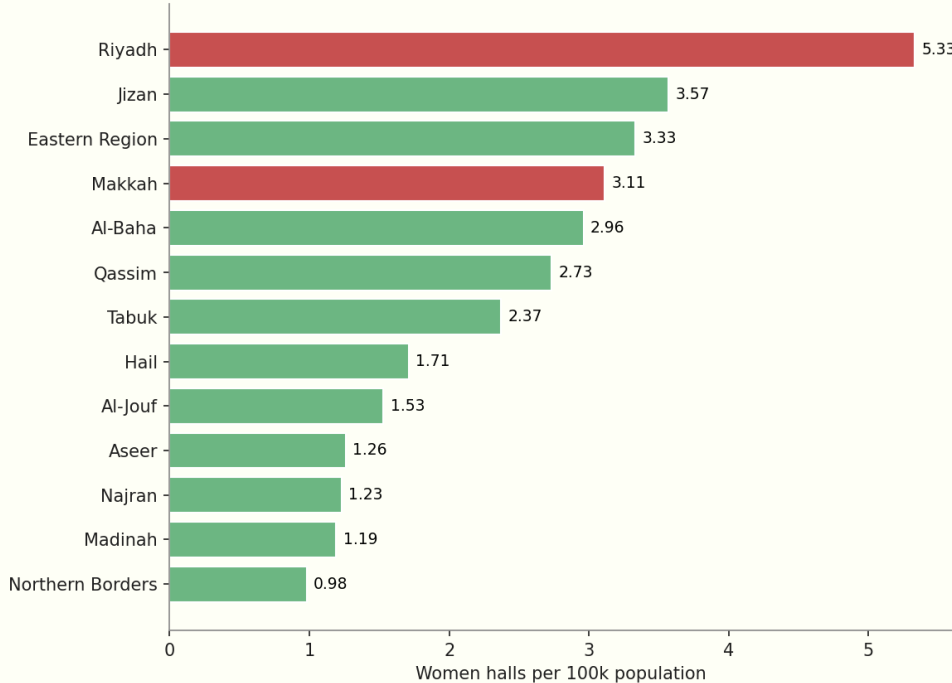
## Recommendation

Treat accreditation as a market-shaping lever. Set a 5-year target of 25% accreditation, starting with the 6 zero-accreditation regions.

Source: SAFF Accredited Clubs & Academies PDF (October 2023, OCR'd, 69 entries). Match rate to facilities table: 32%.

# Q7 — How are women's facilities distributed by region?

Q7 — Women's halls density by region



## Answer

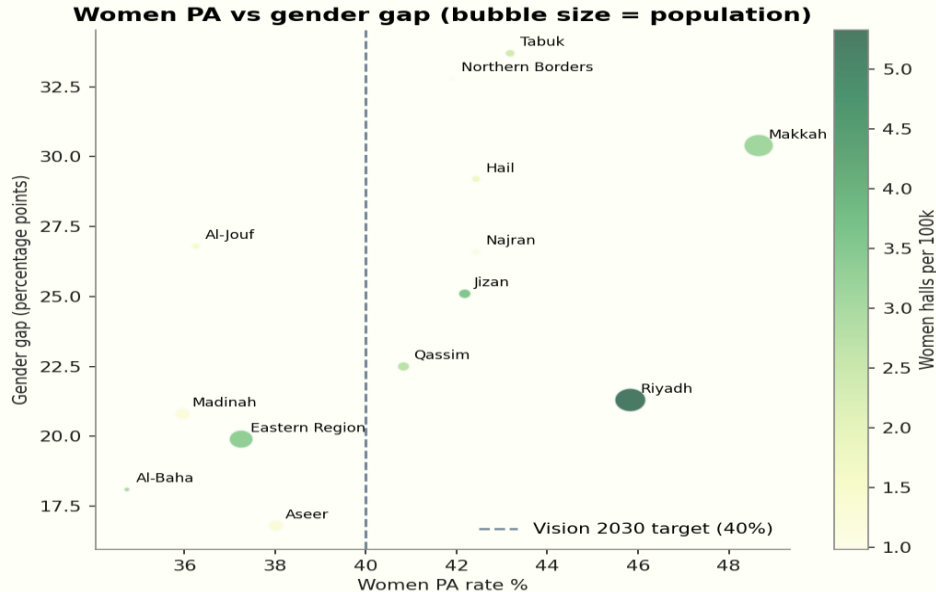
1,175 women halls nationally. Riyadh leads at 5 per 100k woman. Northern Borders lowest at 0.98. 5x spread mirrors total facility density.

## Recommendation

Prioritize Northern Borders (0.98) and Aseer (1.26) for women's-specific facilities.

Source: MOS Open Data: المراكز الرياضية والصالات (commercial halls register, 2024).

## Q8 — How does women's PA relate to women's infrastructure?



### Answer

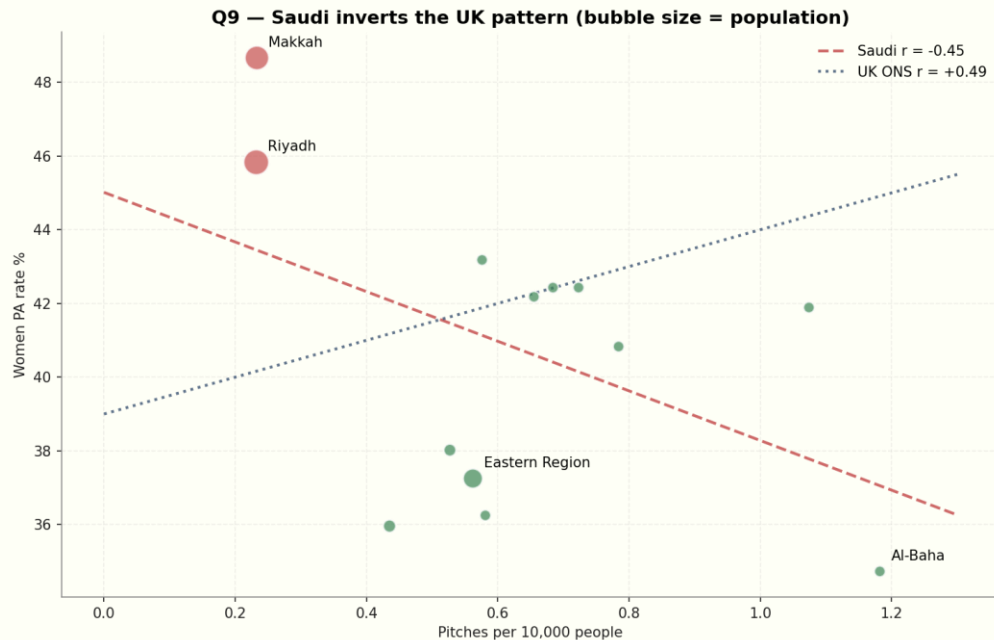
Megaregions show highest women PA (45-49%) but lowest hall density per capita. National women PA 43% — already above Vision 2030 40% target.

### Recommendation

Re-tag programming, allocate women-only hours, recruit female coaches.

Source: GASTAT 2025 Physical Activity Statistics + 2021 Sports Practice Survey (hybrid estimate, calibrated to 43.06% national).

# Q9 — Does pitch density correlate with PA rate?



## Answer

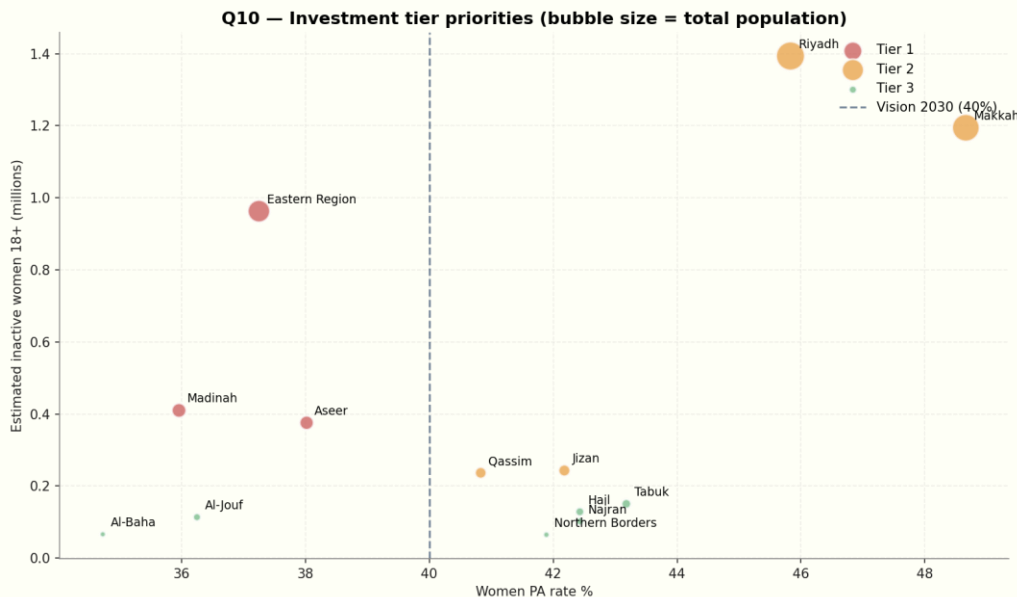
Saudi  $r = -0.24$  (pop-weighted  $-0.54$ ). Inverts UK ONS  $r = +0.49$ . For women specifically  $r = -0.70$  weighted. Building more pitches will not lift PA at the regional grain.

## Recommendation

Replicate the megaregion mix — gyms, walkable streets, mixed-use facilities — in Eastern, Madinah, and Aseer instead of defaulting to pitch builds. Riyadh and Makkah hit the highest women's PA on the lowest pitch density.

Source: Replicates UK ONS Sport Participation methodology. 7 hypothesis tests on  $n=13$  regions. UK reference: ONS Sport England 2018-22.

# Q10 — Where should SAFF invest first?



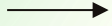
## Answer

Tier 1: Eastern (5.6M, **37.3%** women PA, ~960k inactive), Madinah (2.3M, **36%**), Aseer (2.2M, **38%**). Combine LOW women PA with LARGE inactive populations — highest absolute opportunity for Vision 2030 lift.

## Recommendation

Tier 1 — Eastern, Madinah, Aseer first. Convert capacity (don't build), seed SWPL-affiliated academies, recruit 50 female coaches in 24 months.

**Source:** Q10 priorities view: combines pop-weighted women PA gap × inactive women count × women halls density. Tier thresholds: women PA <40% AND inactive women >300k.



Seven actions grounded in Q1–Q10

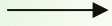
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# Recommendations

# Recommendations

*All recommendations grounded in the statistics from Q1–Q10*

- 1. Re-tag, don't build.** 0.43 pitches/10k nationally (Q1) and  $r=-0.24$  PA correlation (Q9) show new construction will not lift PA. Convert under-utilized capacity in well-served regions for women's hours.
- 2. Lead with women's programming in 3 regions.** Eastern (5.6M, 37.3% women PA), Madinah (2.3M, 36%), Aseer (2.2M, 38%) hold the largest absolute opportunity (Q10). Recruit 50 female coaches there in 24 months.
- 3. Refresh the academy list and use accreditation as a market lever.** The 4.6% rate (Q6) is from the Oct 2023 SAFF list — update it with 2025-26 data, then set a 5-year target of 25%, starting with the 6 zero-accreditation regions.
- 4. Fill desert pockets in Riyadh and Makkah.** 55% / 56% of urban area beyond 2 km from any pitch (Q3). Re-tag existing pitches and add school partnerships before greenfield construction.
- 5. Use Google ratings as soft quality signal — above 50 reviews only.** 96% of facilities are rated; 47% have 50+ reviews at mean 4.21★ (Q5). Build SAFF-verified badges to displace noisy ratings below 10 reviews.
- 6. Don't replicate Riyadh's 5 women halls per 100k elsewhere.** Prioritize Northern Borders (0.98) and Aseer (1.26) for women's-specific facilities (Q7). Capacity is uneven, not absent.



Saudi vs Germany / Japan / Türkiye in 3 categories

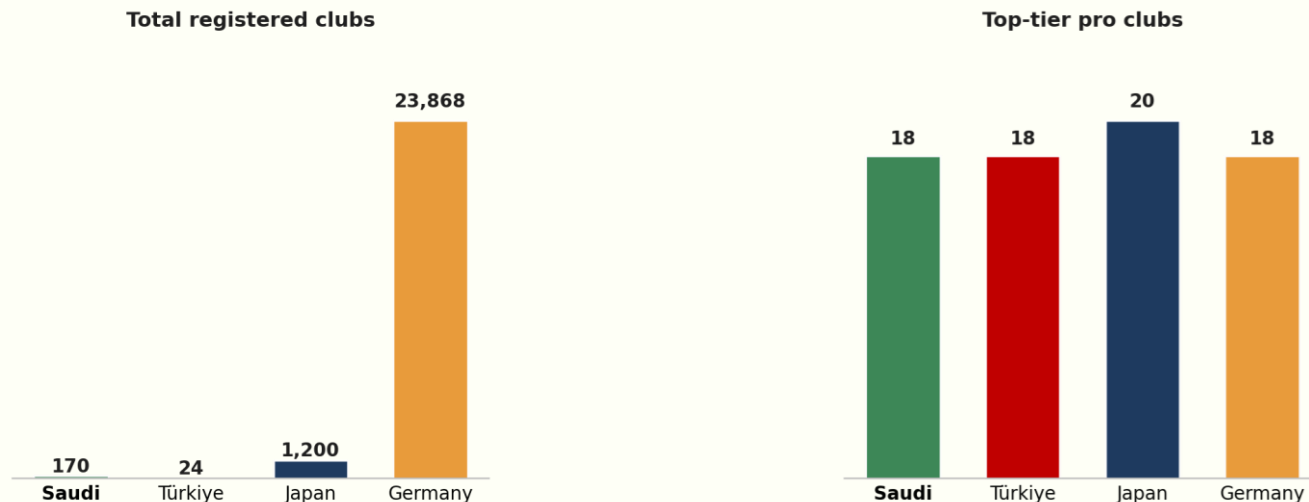
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# Benchmark



# Benchmark — Football Clubs

Verified federation data, 2024–25



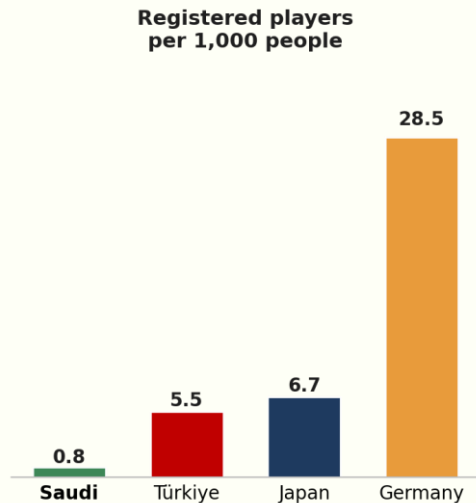
Saudi has 170 SAFF clubs across all 4 divisions vs Germany's 23,868 (DFB).

Top-tier comparable across all 4 countries (18–20 clubs).

Source: Saudi: SAFF / Saudipedia 2024. Germany: DFB Mitgliederstatistik 2024/25. Türkiye: TFF licensed clubs 2024-25. Japan: JFA / J-League 2024.

# Benchmark — Academies & pipeline

*Registered players per 1,000 people — pipeline depth across 4 countries*

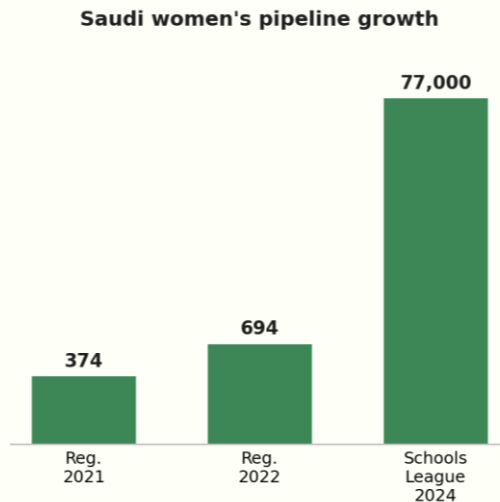


Saudi at 0.85 per 1,000. Germany at 28.5 — a 33x gap. Türkiye 5.50, Japan 6.73 are nearer peers.

**Source:** Germany: DFB 2024/25 (2.38M active ÷ 83.4M pop). Japan: JFA Mar 2024 (834,420 ÷ 124M). Türkiye: TFF (466,445 ÷ 85.5M). MOS open data ~30,000 registered players.

# Benchmark — Women's football Grassroots

*From Grassroots to Professional : Scaling the Woman's Football Pipeline*



Pipeline growth: +106% in one year + 77,000 in Schools League.

+195% professional women's player growth since 2018 (NEOM/SAFF report Jan 2025).

**Source:** Saudi: SAFF VP statement (FIFA Women's Convention 2023), NEOM/SAFF Women's Football Report Jan 2025.



“Our nation has the potential to be a global force for sport. Football, more than any other game, can carry that ambition forward — when we build the pipeline, the pitches, and the women’s game alongside the men’s.”

—Aligned with Vision 2030 Quality of Life Programme

# Thank you

Saudi Football Study — Prepared by Abdulrahman Bajunaid

*Questions and discussion*

# References & sources

*Every data point in this deck traces back to one of the sources below*

## Demand-side data

- GASTAT Census 2022 + 2024 estimates
- GASTAT Physical Activity Statistics 2025
- GASTAT Sports Practice Survey 2021

## Methodology references

- UK ONS Sport Participation methodology (Q9)
- UEFA / Sport England — per-10k denominators
- Wilson 95% CI with finite-population correction

## Saudi women's football

- SAFF VP Lamia Bahaian, FIFA Women's Football Convention 2023
- NEOM / SAFF Women's Football Report (Jan 2025)

## Supply-side data

- Google Places API (1,997 facilities, Apr 2026)
- SAFF Accredited Clubs PDF (Oct 2023, OCR'd)
- MOS Open Data — commercial halls (2024)

## Benchmark country sources

- DFB Mitgliederstatistik 2024/25 (Germany)
- JFA registered players Mar 2024 (Japan)
- TFF licensed players (Türkiye)